

California - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | ACC

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Bowl-line Power Four team with a stable quarterback but a wide defensive/new-staff range.
Preseason consensus	AP Others receiving votes (2 points) · ACC media poll: 12th (1,392 points) · SP+ No. 60 (+3.0)
Returning production	58% (No. 46) overall · Off. 70% (No. 11) · Def. 45% (No. 92)
Primer power rating	+3.0 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	5.9 wins · most likely 6-6
Net vs. 2025	● ↔ Roughly similar overall, with a better continuity story on offense offset by much greater defensive turnover and a completely new staff.
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: California's safest 2026 identity is a quarterback-centered offense built around returning starter QB Jaron-Keawe Sagapolutele and a rebuilt transfer skill group, paired with a low-continuity defense being remade under Tosh Lupoi and Michael Hutchings. The exact new-scheme identity remains unclear, so the central question is whether offensive continuity can carry the team while the defense and line combinations settle.

Bottom line: Cal has enough quarterback/offensive continuity to reach a bowl again, but defensive attrition, new-system variance and unresolved line/specialist roles keep the Bears closer to a toss-up six-win team than a dependable upper-half ACC team.

Beats expectations if: QB Sagapolutele turns 2025 volume into better efficiency, RB Adam Mohammed and the new receiving group lift a run/explosive profile that was poor in 2025, and the transfer-heavy defense finds competent replacements quickly.

Disappoints if: The rebuilt OL cannot improve a weak rushing/success-rate baseline, the defense feels its 45% returning-production signal and heavy secondary/front losses, and the new staff needs longer than the schedule allows to stabilize roles.

Five things to remember

- 2025 baseline:** QB Jaron-Keawe Sagapolutele is an established returning QB1 after 3,454 passing yards and 18 TD in 2025; quarterback is not the preseason mystery here.
- Returning production:** Returning production is sharply split: offense 70% (No. 11) versus defense 45% (No. 92).
- ♦ **New play-caller:** OC Jordan Somerville is the 2026 offensive play-caller.
- Returning production:** The defense loses major contributors including CB Hezekiah Masses, CB Brent Austin, DB Dru Polidore Jr., DL Aidan Keanaaina and LB Cade Uluave, so the low returning-production signal reflects real high-snap turnover.
- Schedule pressure:** SP+ projects 5.9 wins with SOS No. 63; the opener vs. UCLA and later Virginia Tech/Wake Forest/NC State/Pittsburgh cluster are true bowl-path swing games.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	7-6 (4-4 ACC)	● Average / bowl-level
Scoring	25.3 PPG	● Below average
Total offense	357.6 YPG	● Below average
Rush offense	81.7 YPG · 2.8 YPC	● Very poor
Pass efficiency	7.09 YPA · 20 TD / 10 INT	● Average / mixed
Third downs	40.7%	● Average / mixed
Scoring defense	27.2 PPG allowed	● Average / mixed
Total defense	361.8 YPG allowed	● Average / mixed
Rush defense	156.6 YPG · 4.7 YPC	● Average / mixed
Pass defense	205.2 YPG · 6.35 YPA · 14 TD allowed	● Good / above average

The 2025 offense was modest overall but badly unbalanced: scoring No. 86, total offense No. 89 and rushing No. 135, while passing volume was much healthier. The defense was closer to average in yards allowed (No. 62) and relatively better in pass-efficiency defense (No. 39) than in scoring (No. 82) or rushing defense (No. 79).

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	-1.23 · No. 71	● Average / mixed
Off. EPA/play	-0.038 · No. 80	● Average / mixed
Off. success rate	40.0% · No. 101	● Below average
Off. explosive-play rate	9.9% · No. 121	● Very poor
Havoc allowed	16.4% · No. 91	● Below average
Opp.-adjusted defense	-1.61 · No. 78	● Average / mixed
Def. EPA/play allowed	+0.013 · No. 69	● Average / mixed
Def. success rate allowed	41.0% · No. 60	● Average / mixed
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	12.3% · No. 76	● Average / mixed
Havoc created	15.3% · No. 75	● Average / mixed

Advanced-stat read: Cal’s 7-6 record did not hide an efficient underlying team: the offense was poor in success and explosiveness and the defense sat around or below average in adjusted/EPA terms. The 2026 upside case therefore depends on real improvement-especially in rushing/OL efficiency-rather than simple positive regression, while the defense must improve despite substantially less continuity.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	♦ Tosh Lupoi - from Oregon DC/LB; returning to Cal	● ↔ A full staff transition adds uncertainty even with a strong defensive background.
OC / play-caller	♦ Jordan Somerville - from Tampa Bay assistant QBs; primary 2026 offensive game-day play-caller	● ↔ Owns the offensive play-calling role around a returning QB1; the system itself is new.
DC	♦ Michael Hutchings - from Minnesota Vikings safeties coach; Da’Von Brown is co-DC/DB	● ↔ Inherits a low-continuity defense, so personnel integration is the main early test.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
♦ RB Adam Mohammed	Washington	● ↑ 523 rushing yards/five TD in 2025, lead-back candidate and a plausible upgrade path for a rushing offense that ranked No.135.
♦ WR Ian Strong	Rutgers	● ↔ Projected starter/major target and fully back in practice by Aug.20, but his 2026 role remains projection-level.
♦ WR Chase Hendricks	Ohio	● ↔ Expected starter/major rotation with Biletnikoff watchlist recognition; adds upside to a rebuilt receiver room.

Out	To	Loss
WR/RET Jacob De Jesus	NFL (Kansas City), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Major receiving and return production departs after 108 catches/1,029 receiving yards plus a major return role.
IOL Jordan Spasojevic-Moko	CFL (Toronto)	● ↓ Thirteen-game 2025 starter leaves a line that already needs improvement.

Offensive net: ● ↔ Potentially better at the headline skill spots because QB1 returns and the staff added multiple weapons, but OL continuity and the loss of WR/RET Jacob De Jesus keep the upgrade unproven.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
♦ DB Ricky Fletcher	Ole Miss	● ↔ Starter candidate with meaningful prior role information, but late-camp availability/role is still being worked back.
♦ ILB Kamar Mothudi	Oregon	● ↔ Another starter/major-rotation candidate in a rebuilt linebacker group; he is not yet a proven upgrade.
♦ OLB Solomon Williams	Texas A&M	● ↔ An additional starter/major-rotation candidate in the rebuilt edge group.

Out	To	Loss
CB Hezekiah Masses	NFL (Las Vegas), Round 5, No. 175	● ↓ Thirteen starts, 47 tackles and five interceptions leave the secondary.
CB Brent Austin	NFL (Denver), undrafted free agent	● ↓ All-ACC corner with 13 pass breakups departs.
DB Dru Polidore Jr.	football retirement	● ↓ Nine-start/62-tackle 2025 safety ends his football career.
DL Aidan Keanaaina	NFL (Detroit), undrafted free agent	● ↓ 2025 starting defensive lineman departs.
LB Cade Uluave	BYU	● ↓ Material linebacker departure increases reliance on a transfer-heavy replacement group.

Defensive net: ● ↓ Worse on continuity and proven production; the defense is the main source of team-level downside until the transfer replacements establish themselves.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Quarterback-centered and likely pass-leaning by personnel/2025 baseline, but the exact new-system identity is not yet clear.	QB Sagapolutele's continuity plus a deep set of transfer skill options and two returning tight ends.	Run-game/OL efficiency: 2025 rushing offense ranked No.135, success rate No.101 and explosive rate No.121.
Defense	New Lupoi/Hutchings defensive operation with a transfer-heavy front and secondary; the final scheme identity remains unsettled.	The 2025 pass-efficiency defense was the best traditional component (No.39), and several incoming transfers project into immediate roles.	Low continuity and the loss of multiple proven corners, a starting DL, linebackers and a nine-start safety.
Special teams	Reset at punter/returner with an unresolved kicker competition.	K McGough had the strongest late-camp kicker-battle report.	No official kicker lock, primary punter transfer, major returner departure and SP+ special teams No.95.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B+	● ↔	High	QB Jaron-Keawe Sagapolutele returns after starting all 13 games in 2025.
RB	● B–	● ↑	Medium	RB Adam Mohammed provides a plausible upgrade path for a poor 2025 run game.
WR	● B–	● ↔	Medium-low	WR Ian Strong and WR Chase Hendricks add options, but the room is rebuilt.
TE	● B	● ↔	Medium-high	TE Dorian Thomas provides useful continuity for the returning quarterback.
OL	● C+	● ↔	Low	A rebuilt line must improve 2025 rushing efficiency and havoc allowed.
DL/Edge	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	Transfer additions must replace substantial front turnover.
LB	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	ILB Kamar Mothudi is a key piece in a group replacing material contributors.
Secondary	● C+	● ↓	Low	DB Ricky Fletcher is a key replacement piece in a heavily changed back end.
Special teams	● C	● ↓	Low	Punter and return roles reset while placekicker remains unsettled.
Coaching	● B	● ↔	Low	The entire staff is new; role clarity exists, but installation risk is high.
Overall	● B–	● ↔	Medium-low	Bowl-line profile with QB continuity offset by defensive and staff turnover.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: preseason honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Jaron-Keawe Sagapolutele	QB	● Established Power Four starter / team stabilizer	Maxwell	Started all 13 games in 2025 with 3,454 passing yards and 18 TD; his continuity is the main reason the offense has a credible floor.
◆ Adam Mohammed (TR: Washington)	RB	● Projected lead back / key upgrade candidate	Doak Walker · Paul Hornung	523 rushing yards/five TD in 2025 and a lead-back role make him central to fixing a rushing offense that ranked No.135.
◆ Ian Strong (TR: Rutgers)	WR	● Projected starter / major target	Biletnikoff	Back fully in practice by Aug.20 and projected as a major target in the rebuilt receiver room.
◆ Chase Hendricks (TR: Ohio)	WR	● Projected starter / upside receiver	Biletnikoff	One of the primary transfer receivers expected to replace major lost production.
Dorian Thomas	TE	● Established receiving tight end	John Mackey	Returning major-role TE gives Sagapolutele one of the offense's few continuity pieces beyond quarterback.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
◆ Ricky Fletcher (TR: Ole Miss)	DB	● Projected secondary starter / availability monitor	-	Expected to help replace a large corner/safety departure class, but he was still working back into full camp activity as of Aug.20.
◆ Kamar Mothudi (TR: Oregon)	ILB	● Projected starter / major-rotation linebacker	-	Cal needs him to stabilize a linebacker group that lost Cade Uluave and Harrison Taggart.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Manageable enough to make a bowl realistic, but the schedule contains many near-peer games rather than many true layups.
Difficulty	● 5/10 · Moderate · SP+ SOS No. 63
Hardest stretch	at SMU → at NC State → bye → at Virginia
Swing games	UCLA, at Syracuse, Virginia Tech, Wake Forest, at NC State, Pittsburgh
Advantage	Six home games, including UCLA, Virginia Tech, Wake Forest, Stanford and Pittsburgh; bye before the road trip to Virginia.
Expected	5.9 wins · most likely 6-6
Floor / ceiling	4-8 / 8-4

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	Likely bowl-line team whose pricing should be highly opponent-dependent because many games fall near a one-score model range.
Back them when	The price does not fully credit QB Sagapolutele's continuity and Cal faces a defense that can be attacked through the pass without forcing the rebuilt OL/run game to carry the offense.
Fade/pass when	The matchup demands consistent rushing efficiency or exposes the new defensive back seven/front against proven high-end offenses; avoid assuming the defensive rebuild is solved before information appears.
Key monitor	Final OL combination, DB Ricky Fletcher availability/role, Kicker winner, Early performance of transfer-heavy defense
Week 1 baseline	California +0.5 vs. UCLA · essentially a pick'em on the primer ratings; compare with the live market before betting. Live market: California +1.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Cal's best source of stability is QB Jaron-Keawe Sagapolutele, who returns with a reworked skill group and a new staff trying to improve a weak rushing/efficiency profile. OL continuity is still the main offensive constraint.

The defense carries the larger downside after heavy front and secondary attrition, so a bowl bid depends on transfers stabilizing quickly. The preseason baseline remains a near-toss-up six-win profile rather than a dependable upper-half ACC projection.

About this primer

DRWhittier · cfb.drwhittier.com · X: [@GatorBait7](https://twitter.com/GatorBait7) · Version 1.0 - August 25, 2026

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [ACC media day](#) · [roster additions](#) · [fall camp](#) · [NFL draft exit](#) · [NFL UDFA exits](#) · [CFL draft exit](#)

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